

Lectern: a short guide

Lectern is a PDF reader that can read your documents out loud. Open any PDF, press play, and the page follows the voice: the sentence being spoken is lit in amber so your eyes never lose the thread.

This sample document exists so you can hear it working right away. It has four pages, a few headings, a numbered list, and some of the awkward things real documents contain, e.g. abbreviations like Dr. Hughes, decimals such as 3.14, and footers with page numbers.

Why read aloud?

Listening is a different way of paying attention. Long reports, contracts, and course readings are easier to get through when a voice carries them, and proofreading your own writing is far more effective when you hear it rather than skim it. Lectern keeps the page in view the whole time, so you can switch between listening and reading whenever you like.

Getting started

1. Open a PDF with the Open button, or drop a file anywhere on the window.
2. Choose a voice and a speed in the Read aloud panel on the right.
3. Press play, or click any sentence on the page to start reading from there.

Controls that matter

The transport bar at the bottom of the window works like a music player. Play and pause are one button. The skip buttons move one sentence backward or forward, which is useful when you missed a clause or want to hear a definition again.

Speed goes from half speed to double speed. Most people settle somewhere between 1.1 and 1.4 once they are used to a voice. Pitch is there for comfort rather than accuracy; a slightly lower pitch is easier to listen to for long stretches.

Follow along

When Follow the voice is switched on, the page scrolls itself to keep the current sentence in view. Switch it off if you want to flick ahead through the document while the reading continues in the background. The transcript on the right always stays in step with the voice regardless of where the page is.

Skipping clutter

Page numbers, running headers, and lone figure labels are tiresome to hear. The Skip page numbers option drops sentences that are nothing but a number or a Page 2 of 4 style footer. Everything else is read exactly as written, including this sentence.

Searching and navigating

The search box in the toolbar looks through the whole document. Matches are tinted teal on the page, and Enter steps through them one at a time. Shift and Enter steps backward. Press Escape to clear the search and return to the page you were on.

The sidebar on the left shows page thumbnails. If the document has bookmarks, an Outline tab appears beside the thumbnails and lists the chapters so you can jump straight to one.

Zoom

Zoom works the way you expect: the plus and minus buttons, Ctrl and the mouse wheel, or the preset list which also offers Fit width and Fit page. Rotation turns the whole document a quarter turn at a time, which helps with scanned pages that arrived sideways.

Keyboard shortcuts

Space plays and pauses. Shift with the left or right arrow skips a sentence. The plain arrow keys and Page Up and Page Down move between pages. Ctrl and F opens search. Shortcuts are ignored while you are typing in a text field.

Notes on voices

Lectern uses the voices installed on your computer, so quality depends on your system. On Windows the natural sounding Microsoft voices are the best choice when they are available; on a Mac the Siri and Enhanced voices are excellent; Chrome also offers its own online voices which need an internet connection.

Your place is remembered. When you reopen a document Lectern returns to the page you were on, and your voice, speed, and pitch settings are kept between sessions. Nothing leaves your computer: the file is read in your browser and never uploaded anywhere.

Where it falls short

Scanned PDFs that contain only images have no text to read. Lectern will show the pages but the Read aloud panel will tell you there is nothing it can speak. Running those files through an OCR tool first solves it. Columns, tables, and footnotes are read in the order the PDF stores them, which is usually, but not always, the order you would read them in.

That is the whole tour. Close this file, open one of your own, and press play.